

ORAKZAI IN KARACHI

“From mountain valleys to one of Pakistan's great cities.”

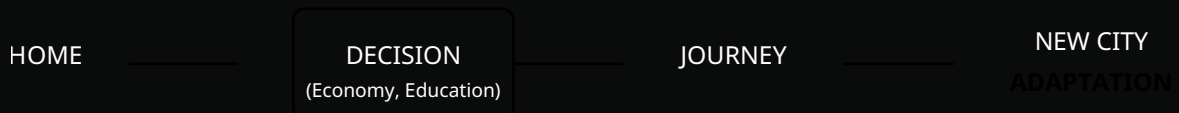
Orakzai does not end at the mountains. For many families, the journey from the homeland eventually leads to a city far from the valleys where earlier generations lived. For some, that city is Karachi. Karachi is one of Pakistan's great destinations of migration. Its history has been shaped by people arriving from across the country and beyond it. Pashtuns have been part of that history for decades. Among them are families whose roots reach back to the tribal districts of the former FATA, including Orakzai. But an important distinction must be made. The history of Pashtuns in Karachi is not automatically the history of Orakzai people in Karachi. Orakzai migration requires its own evidence. Where that evidence exists, it should be documented. Where it does not, the gap should be acknowledged. The story of Orakzai in Karachi is therefore both a migration story and a research story.



“The visual transition from the Orakzai highlands to the coastal metropolis of Karachi.”

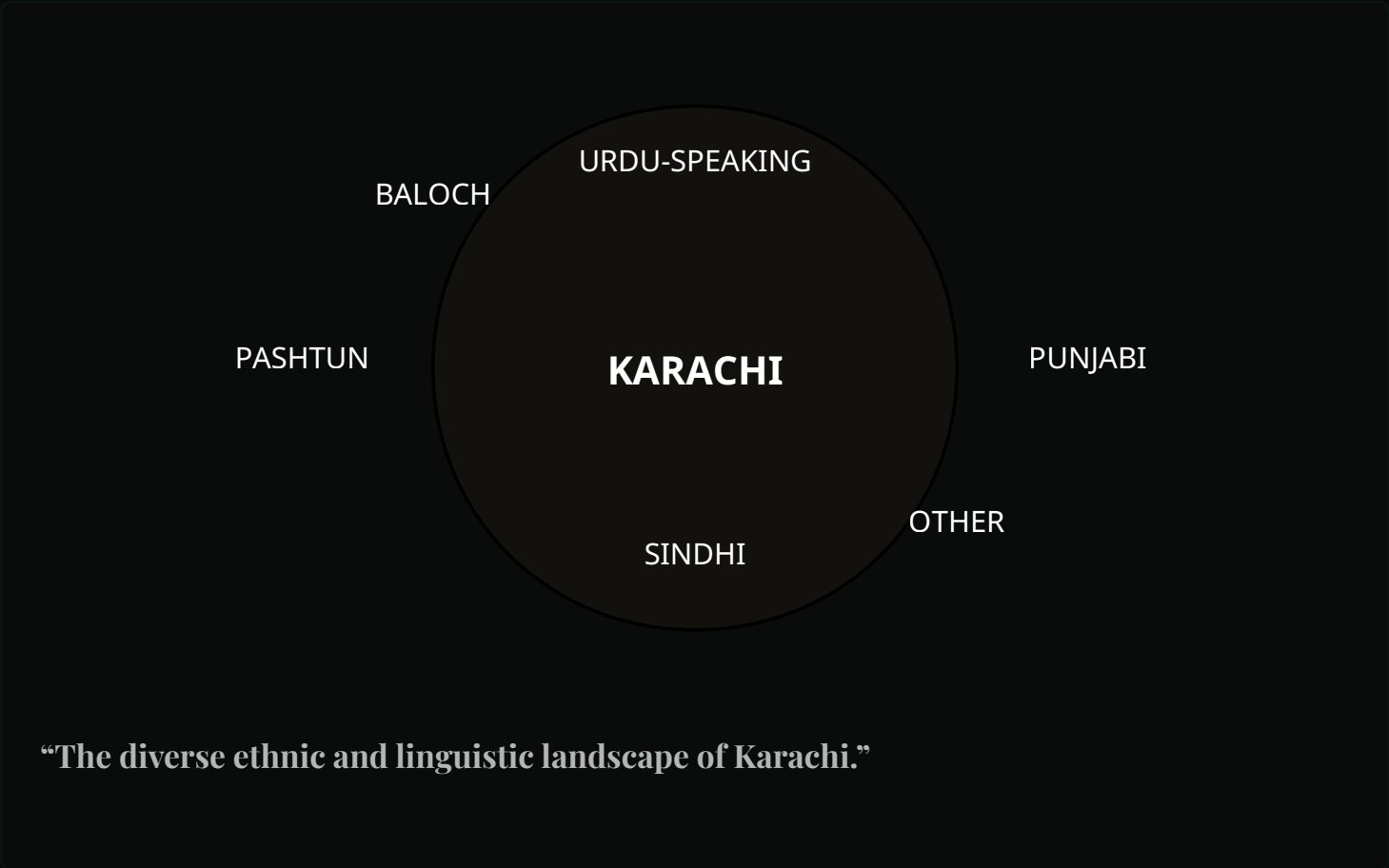
WHAT DOES MIGRATION MEAN?

Migration is not a single experience. It can be driven by economic necessity, educational aspiration, family ties, or security concerns. For Orakzai families, the decision to move to Karachi often involves a complex calculation of risk and opportunity, balanced against the enduring pull of the homeland.³



“The conceptual stages of the Orakzai migration journey.”

Karachi is a city of incredible diversity. It has been shaped by successive waves of migration, including Urdu-speaking communities after Partition, and subsequent arrivals of Sindhis, Pashtuns, Punjabis, Baloch, and others. Within this vast urban fabric, Pashtuns have established themselves as a major demographic and economic force.^{1 2}



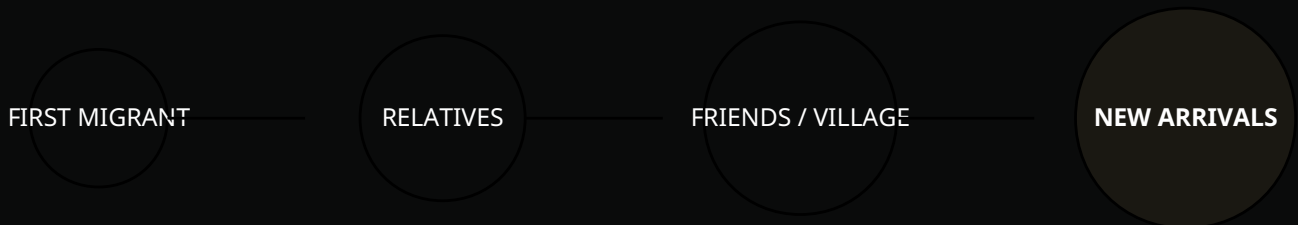
PASHTUN MIGRATION TO KARACHI

Academic research documents decades of Pashtun settlement in Karachi, starting in the 1950s. Initially attracted by industrial growth and construction, Pashtun migrants eventually expanded into the transport, retail, and informal sectors. Today, Karachi is often cited as the city with the largest Pashtun population in the world.^{1 2}

ERA	ECONOMIC DRIVER	SETTLEMENT NATURE	EVIDENCE LEVEL
1950s–1960s	Industrial / Construction	Labor Colonies	High (Oxford)
1970s–1980s	Transport / Retail	Urban Expansion	High (IGC)
2000s–Present	Security / Services	Diverse Settlement	High (Academic)

MIGRATION NETWORKS

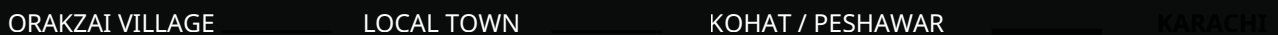
Migration is rarely a random event. It is often a networked process where a "first migrant" establishes a base, followed by relatives and friends from the same village or tribe. This "chain migration" reduces the costs and uncertainties of moving to a new city.³



“The social network model of chain migration.”

FROM VILLAGE TO CITY

Migration can occur in stages. A family may first move to a local town like Kalaya, then to a regional hub like Kohat or Peshawar, before eventually reaching Karachi. This staged migration allows for gradual adaptation and the building of resources.⁴



“The possible staged pathway of migration from the highland to the city.”

A sense of home is created in Karachi through the maintenance of language, family life, and shared memory. While the physical environment is urban, the social and cultural environment often reflects the values of the Orakzai homeland.⁷



AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

Orakzai in Karachi is a story of resilience and adaptation. It is the story of families who have carried their mountains with them to the sea. When I walk through the streets of Banaras or Sohrab Goth, I hear the same Pashto that echoes through the valleys of Kalaya. I see the same hospitality, the same respect for elders, and the same commitment to family. Karachi has changed our people—it has given them new opportunities and new challenges—but it has not erased who they are. We are Orakzai, whether we stand on a mountain peak or a city street. Our identity is not a place; it is a way of being in the world.

“OUR IDENTITY IS NOT A PLACE; IT IS A WAY OF BEING.”

